

As the gross numbers get larger, accessibility becomes more and more important. It is hard to visualize what it means if the number of website hits goes down from 250,000 in one month to 200,000 the next month, but most people understand immediately what it means to lose 50,000 customers. That's practically a whole stadium full of people who are abandoning the product.

Accessibility also refers to widespread access to the reports. Grockit did this especially well. Every day their system automatically generated a document containing the latest data for every single one of their split-test experiments and other leap-of-faith metrics. This document was mailed to every employee of the company: they all always had a fresh copy in their e-mail in-boxes. The reports were well laid out and easy to read, with each experiment and its results explained in plain English.

Another way to make reports accessible is to use a technique we developed at IMVU. Instead of housing the analytics or data in a separate system, our reporting data and its infrastructure were considered part of the product itself and were owned by the product development team. The reports were available on our website, accessible to anyone with an employee account.

Each employee could log in to the system at any time, choose from a list of all current and past experiments, and see a simple one-page summary of the results. Over time, those one-page summaries became the de facto standard for settling product arguments throughout the organization. When people needed evidence to support something they had learned, they would bring a printout with them to the relevant meeting, confident that everyone they showed it to would understand its meaning.

Auditable

When informed that their pet project is a failure, most of us are tempted to blame the messenger, the data, the manager, the gods, or anything else we can think of. That's why the third A of good metrics, "auditable," is so essential. We must ensure that the data is